

Where to put only

Learner workbook

Make clear what you are limiting.

Understand the distinction

Only limits a person, thing, action, amount, or time. Put it close to the element you want to limit when clarity matters: Only Jo called means nobody else called; Jo called only Sam means Sam was the only recipient.

In speech, stress and context also shape the meaning. I only bought two can be understood naturally even if only is not immediately before two. Do not assume every everyday placement is wrong; revise when a reader could misunderstand.

Compare the patterns

PERSON

Only Jo called Sam.

Nobody other than Jo called Sam.

RECIPIENT

Jo called only Sam.

Jo called no one except Sam.

ACTION

Jo only called; she did not visit.

The action was limited to a call.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Which says Sam was the sole recipient: Only Jo called Sam / Jo called only Sam?

2. Rewrite clearly: No one except Leo replied.

3. Can spoken stress help clarify only?

Use it in your own life

Write two sentences in which moving only changes the meaning.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Jo called only Sam.

Only limits Sam.

2. Only Leo replied.

Only is next to the person being limited.

3. Yes. Stress and context can identify the focus.

In writing, a clearer position may help.

One possible response

Only Ana ordered tea. Ana ordered only tea.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-18.html